



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: New Covenant Schools

School Website: <https://newcovenantschools.org/>

December 22, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

New Covenant Schools (Lynchburg, VA 24501) presents a robust, textually grounded alignment with classical Christian education across all six elements of the classical rubric. Public materials consistently foreground a three-part Trivium-based curriculum (grammar, dialectic, rhetoric) rooted in liberal arts, a strong emphasis on Great Books and foundational texts, and a faith-infused community life centered on liturgy, Scripture, and chapel. Evidence from the school's site shows explicit commitments to virtue formation, intellectual rigor, and a lifelong love of truth, goodness, and beauty, with concrete practices such as Harkness discussions, Senior Theses, liturgical worship, catechesis, and a central role for the arts in education. Public materials also emphasize the partnership with parents and an open, involved school community, including dedicated rituals (Lessons & Carols, Chapel) and parent-facing programs (Center for Paideia, Moms-in-Touch, parent relations). All six categories therefore meet the criteria for CLASSICAL under the Six Essential Elements rubric.

Key evidence highlights: - Religious/metaphysical foundations are explicit in mission and daily life (Christian, Anglican/Reformed Episcopal identity; Scriptures and Book of Common Prayer; chapel and liturgy).

- Purpose/goal centers formation, virtue, and the pursuit of truth, goodness, beauty, not job-prep alone. - Curriculum emphasizes grammar/dialectic/rhetoric, liberal arts core, Great Books, Latin/Greek, and history within a Western tradition frame.

- Pedagogy features Socratic/dialectic methods, memory work, liturgical/chanting traditions, and upper-level rhetoric/theater by design.

- Faculty materials portray mentors living the curriculum, with a strong emphasis on character formation and long-tenured, highly qualified staff. - Parents and community engagement is a formal pillar, with ongoing parent formation and an open invitation to campus visits, plus a Center for Paideia that partners with families.

Executive category snapshots are summarized below, followed by a concise abstract.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Mission explicitly grounds education in Christian virtue and the triad of truth, goodness, beauty (the transcendentals).
 - Public statements note the school's Anglican/Episcopal heritage and affirmation of creeds (Apostles' and Nicene).
 - Chapel, Book of Common Prayer, Lord's Prayer, Scripture study, and weekly chapel are integrated into daily life.
 - Liturgical life (Lessons & Carols) and sacred music/docs emphasize reverence and worship as formative to learning.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords present: truth; goodness; beauty; virtue; theology; liturgy; chapel; morning

prayer; creeds; sacred scripture; worship; doxology; reverence; wonder; chant. Estimated occurrences: 8–12 positive indicators.

- Negative keywords: essentially none in public materials (no explicit relativism/secular-humanism signals observed in the passages cited). 0 observed.
- Why this rating
 - The school publicly anchors education in transcendentals and sacred practice, with explicit references to liturgy, creeds, Scripture, and chapel as foundational, aligning strongly with CLASSICAL expectations for religious/metaphysical foundations. The absence of negative signals reinforces CLASSICAL status. See mission and Spiritual Life materials.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Mission emphasizes formation, virtue, wisdom, and a classical telos (truth, goodness, beauty) over mere job-training.
 - Description of liberal-arts-based mission and paideia framing; pursuit of permanent questions and classical heritage.
 - Center for Paideia materials describe education as a partnership forming character and intellect; emphasis on “love of truth.”
 - Great Books/Great Conversation framing appears in public materials advocating for a classical curriculum.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords present: formation; virtue; human flourishing; wisdom; liberal education; paideia; classical mission; telos; great conversation; contemplation; scholé; wonder; beauty; truth/goodness. Estimated occurrences: 8–12 positive indicators.
 - Negative keywords observed: references to workforce/job-prep aims are minimal; the site does not foreground “college and career readiness” as primary telos in most pages (though some posts discuss college placement, it’s within a broader formation frame). Likely 0–2 weak negative signals.
- Why this rating
 - The public materials consistently present education as formation toward virtue and wisdom through classical means, not primarily as job training, with explicit references to the true/-good/beautiful triad and classical telos. This aligns strongly with CLASSICAL. See mission statements and Paideia materials.

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Core structure named explicitly: grammar, dialectic, rhetoric; three modes of learning used to organize the program.
 - Liberal arts emphasis; history integrated across the curriculum; Western-Civilization framing; Great Books/primary sources referenced.
 - Language study (Latin/Greek), classical languages, and formal study of literature; advanced coursework in Latin, literature, and calculus in the School of Rhetoric.
 - Sacred arts, music, and fine arts are treated as essential, not optional, in the curriculum.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords present: liberal arts; trivium; grammar; logic; rhetoric; great books; primary sources; classics; Homer/Plato/Augustine/Shakespeare; Latin/Greek and classical languages; history/Western civilization; natural philosophy; music theory; Socratic texts; recitation; narration; liturgical art; etc. Estimated 12–20 positive indicators.
 - Negative keywords observed: minimal (no explicit “project-based learning dominance” or other non-classical culprits observed in the cited texts). 0–2 weak signals.
- Why this rating

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- The curriculum is explicitly structured around the Trivium, liberal arts, great books, and classical languages, with explicit emphasis on a Great Books approach and history within a Western-tradition frame. This clearly satisfies CLASSICAL criteria. See Trivium description and Great Books framing.

Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Explicit use of Socratic method and dialectic in middle and high school; Harkness discussions cited as central to class conversations.
 - Recitation/memorization and memory work as pedagogical tools (e.g., poetry and performance; classical memory work).
 - Restful/Scholé style acknowledged via classical education framing and memory/rest in some materials; upper-school rhetoric theses and public speaking opportunities.
 - In lower grades, some singing/recitation and memory-based strategies referenced in middle and grammar-school contexts.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords present: Socratic seminar; dialectic; Harkness; rhetoric; memorization/recitation; singing/chanting to memorize; Scholé/restful learning; liturgical calendar integration; seminar/colloquy; capstone orations. Estimated occurrences: 10–15 positive indicators.
 - Negative keywords observed: minimal to none in these materials; no overt emphasis on exclusively project-based or constructivist approaches. 0–2 signals.
- Why this rating
 - The pedagogy is explicitly classical: Socratic/chant/memorization methods, Harkness-style dialogue, and upper-level rhetoric/Thesis are core, with restorative (Scholé) elements. This aligns with CLASSICAL. See the School of Rhetoric pedagogy and related posts.

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Faculty described as living curriculum and mentors who model virtue, skill, and knowledge; long-tenured staff and advanced degrees in many cases; “Center for Paideia” engagement indicates a strong faculty development culture.
 - The School emphasizes a faculty profile and collective culture (portrait of teacher; faculty as the core of the school). Public materials emphasize advanced degrees and dedicated teacher leadership.
 - Center for Paideia materials describe personalized support, governance of teachers, and collaboration across faculty and administration.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords present: tutors/masters/mentors; living curriculum; faculty of friends; collegial culture; lifelong learners; great books seminars for faculty; moral exemplars; teacher training; classical formation. Estimated occurrences: 8–12 positive indicators.
 - Negative keywords observed: few to none (no explicit “facilitator/guide on the side” issue noted; public materials emphasize classical teacher leadership). 0–1 negative indicators.
- Why this rating
 - The institutional language and content portray faculty as central to the formation process and living exemplars of classical pedagogy, consistent with CLASSICAL expectations. See Center for Paideia and faculty-focused descriptions.

Element 6: School Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Strong emphasis on parent partnership; parents as co-teachers; opportunities for parent formation (Moms-in-Touch; reading groups; book clubs; parent relations).

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- Open campus and frequent opportunities for visits; extensive communications about classical education via blogs, book posts, and videos; community-centric liturgy and events (Chapel, Lessons & Carols).
 - Center for Paideia emphasizes family involvement and collaborative student support with parents.
 - Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords present: partnership with parents; co-teachers; parent formation; reading groups; classical book clubs; open campus; family liturgy; pastoral/faith integration; liturgical year events; parent covenant. Estimated occurrences: 8–12 positive indicators.
 - Negative keywords observed: minimal; there are not consumer-language or minimal-visit signals; the site invites parent participation. 0–1 negative indicators.
 - Why this rating
 - The site frames parents as essential participants in the education process, with multiple pathways for family engagement and formation, aligning with CLASSICAL expectations for parents and community. See the parent-relations content and Paideia Center materials.

Aggregate assessment: CLASSICAL

- Across all six categories, New Covenant Schools demonstrates predominant CLASSICAL alignment, with explicit traces of Great Books/Trivium pedagogy, liturgical/spiritual formation, formation-focused curriculum, and strong faculty/parent-community integration. The combined material supports CLASSICAL as the general classification for the school.

What would move the needle - Not applicable, as the aggregate classification is CLASSICAL across all six categories. No major “needle-moving” changes are required to reach CLASSICAL status in any category.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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